

What ARE those Aussies talking about?

Learning typical Australian slang expressions has (finally) been made easy! Watch my Australian Slang Conversation Practice, study the 29 words and expressions that are used in everyday Australian English conversations & and practise with the activities on page 6. 'Have a crack' & see how you go!



AUSTRALIAN SLANG WORDS & EXPRESSIONS

These words are presented in the same order that they appear in the lesson.

cuppa /'kʌpə/

Informal slang, common in British and Australian English

(noun) a cup of tea

■ "Drop by for a cuppa tomorrow."

(contraction) a cup of

■ "Would you like a cuppa coffee?"

all good /ɔ:l gʊd/

(phrase) no; I don't want it.

■ [Tim] "Do you want a sanga?"
[Georgia] "I'm all good, thanks. I've just eaten."

(phrase) it's all good

More broadly used by native English speakers to say 'don't worry about it'.

chinwag /'tʃɪnwæg/

Informal slang, common in British and Australian English

(noun) a chat

■ "I rarely see Sarah, so when I do run into her, we have a good chinwag!"

chook /'tʃʊk/

Informal Australian slang

(noun) chicken

■ "Our three chooks lay more than enough eggs to feed the family!"

Note: 'chook' can be used for a whole, roasted chicken (food) or the live animal.

sanga /'sæŋə/

Informal Australian slang

(noun) a sandwich

■ "I'll make some ham sangas for the trip."

legend /'ledʒənd/

(noun) a good person

used to tell someone they are awesome; that they are a good person!

Often used with 'bloody' - if an Australian calls you a 'bloody legend' you are a really awesome!

■ "Thanks, mate. You're a bloody legend!"

(to be) under the pump

Informal Australian slang, but often used in a professional context

(idiom) to be very busy, usually at work

■ "I can't come out tonight, I'm under the pump."

(to) take the piss

Informal slang, common in British and Australian English

(idiom) to be very annoying and unfair

■ "\$20 for a burger - that's taking the piss!"

Note: 'piss' is also slang for urine. So you may hear "I need to take **a** piss" and that means I need to urinate.

pull (one's) head in

Informal slang, common in British and Australian English

(phrase) used to ask someone to discontinue what they are doing or saying

■ "What you said to him was really offensive - pull your head in!"

Buckley's chance /'bʌklɪz tʃæns/

Informal Australian English slang

used to suggest that somebody has little or no hope of achieving a particular aim

- You have Buckley's chance of arriving before 3 o'clock.

Often shortened to: "Buckley's"

- If you think you'll be able to speak with Sarah, you've got Buckley's.

(to) have a crack at (someone) /(h)æv ə kræk ət/

(phrase) to yell at someone; to be angry or upset at someone and vocalise it to them.

- "Our teacher had a crack at us because we missed the bus."

Note: to 'have a crack' (at something) also means to try it!

- "I've never played badminton before, but I thought I'd have a crack!"

(to) stuff up /stʌfʌp/

Informal Australian slang

(phrasal verb) to make a mistake

- "I wanted to bring you a cake but I stuffed up the icing!"

tight /taɪt/

This is informal slang, is common across many Englishes!

(adjective) to have a close relationship

- "We've been hiking together every week for 6 months, so we are pretty tight!"

(a) loose unit /lu:s 'ju:nɪt/

Informal Australian slang

(noun) an unpredictable or uncontrolled person who is liable to cause unintentional damage. Can be used in a serious or playful sense.

- "Most of us agree that Bobby is a loose unit."

(to be) on the piss

Informal (offensive) slang, common in British and Australian English

(idiom) to be drinking alcohol heavily

■ "He's had a big night on the piss."

Similar expressions: (adjective) 'pissed' = drunk

(to) wrap your laughing gear around (something)

(idiom) used when offering something to eat, meaning; eat this!

Your 'laughing gear' (or the 'equipment' you use to laugh) is your mouth! So, when you wrap your laughing gear 'round something, you put your mouth around it and eat it!

■ "Wrap your laughing gear 'round this!"

you beauty! /ju: bju:ti/

(exclamation) great; you're great

■ "You beauty, this looks fantastic!"

footy /fʊdi/

Informal Australian & British English slang *note: phonemes above provide the Australian pronunciation

(noun) football; referring to Australian Rules Football (AFL)

■ "We're going to the footy on Friday."

arvo /ɑ:vəʊ/

This is essential, Australian slang; used by everyone everywhere in Australia!

(noun) afternoon

Note: often linked with 'this'

this arvo = 'sarvo

■ "What are you doing tomorrow arvo? Want to come round for a barbie?"

■ "See you at the pub 'sarvo."

chokkas /tʃɒkəz/

Informal Australian slang

(adjective) crowded or full

■ "I'm not getting in that lift, it's chokkas!"

telly /teli/

This is informal slang, is common across many Englishes!

(noun) television

■ “Turn the telly on, the news is about to start.”

(to be) spewing /spju:ɪŋ/ or /spju:ɪn/

(adjective) angry or annoyed

■ “I’m spewing I missed your birthday party!”

(exclamation) used to show disappointment

■ Tim: “I missed out on tickets”
Georgia: “Spewing!”

(also a verb) ‘to spew’ means to vomit.

knock off /nɒkɒf/

Informal Australian & British English

(phrasal verb) to finish work for the day

■ “What time do you knock off on Friday?”

chuck/pull a sickie

This is Australian slang

(idiom) means have a day off work, on sick-leave

Used when someone takes the day off school/work, pretending that they are sick when they are not actually sick. Often used by students who have a test or assignment due or when they take a day off work to do something more fun/enjoyable.

■ “We are taking the boat out to the islands tomorrow, the weather is looking perfect!
Chuck a sickie and come with us!”

(to) go off /gəʊɒf/

This phrasal verb has many meanings, but in informal Australian slang it can also mean:

(phrasal verb) to be busy, lively, exciting

■ “If Australia makes the finals, Federation Square will be going off!”

“the doggies”

In the video, you heard Emma refer to “the doggies”. She was referring to a football team; the Western Bulldogs. This playfulness with team names happens a LOT in Australian sport! (For example, the Collingwood Magpies are often just ‘the pies’)

(to) get up /gedʌp/

(phrasal verb) to win

■ “I hope the Swannies get up over the Pies!”

bikkie /bɪki/

Informal Australian slang



(noun) biscuit

■ “Can you get me a few bikkies from the buffet?”

one for the road /wʌn fə ðə rəʊd/

Australian slang, often used with the verb ‘take’

(phrase) one last drink before leaving.

An expression that usually refers to a final alcoholic drink before leaving a party or event. Often shortened to (a) ‘roadie’. In the video, Emma used it to refer to food, which is still possible, but less common.

■ Tim: “Do you have to leave already? Have another!”
Georgia: “OK, one for the road!”

Practice

Match the expression that best suits the sentence:

(A) Buckley’s chance (B) knock off (C) under the pump
(D) had a crack at (E) all good

1. I can’t come out tonight. I’m _____ to get this report finished.
2. It hasn’t rained in weeks. There’s _____ the creek has water in it.
3. Let’s grab a drink tonight. What time do you _____?
4. That man in the yellow car just _____ me because I stepped onto the road before the traffic lights changed.
5. Do you want some extra salad on your plate? _____ thanks, I’m full!